

INTERVIEW PRAFUL PATEL

"It's a transitional phase"

Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel tells Assistant Editor SANDEEP UNNITHAN that there are no shortcuts to infrastructure creation and that the present aviation boom comes despite the shortage of infrastructure and opposition from political parties and unions.

Q. Can we allow more flights with the existing pressure on infrastructure?

A. Unless you allow growth, there will be no pressure on infrastructure. Yet, I can say that the experience at Indian airports is far more pleasurable than the experience in the US. Why are you comparing single-airports such as Kuala Lumpur and Dubai with Indian airports? I have to give airports in Agatti, Port Blair, Dibrugarh and Vijayawada the same attention that I give to Mumbai and Delhi. Mumbai and Delhi are world-class airports but with one-fourth of the infrastructure of airports like Dubai and Singapore. There are no problems in Mumbai. Yes, there is a problem at the international terminal in Delhi, but a 22-acre concrete plate is being laid for a new terminal that will be ready in 2010, bigger

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than Heathrow's Terminal 5. We are going through a transitional phase. We have brought in this change despite political and union resistance.

Q. Is the policy of not allowing airports within 150 km correct?

A. These are historic decisions. It will take time to correct them but the new greenfield policy provides for new airports subject to certain conditions. They can't be within five miles from an existing airport, but at some reasonable distance. We need 500 airports by 2020, up from the present 80. We have identified at least 200 airfields which can be activated.

Q. Why don't we invest enough in technology?

A. It is a myth that we are backward in aviation technology. By next year, we will be only the fourth country in the world to have satellite navigation facility. We are working with the European Space Agency and the Federal Aviation Administration to improve traffic handling.

Q. What are the biggest hurdles facing airport development?

A. We are in a high growth phase, and infrastructure is not easy to build in India. Everywhere there are land-related issues, Mumbai has encroachments. Airports belong to the states they are located in and the states should be more proactive when they are being constructed.

the next five years. The lack of room for expansion—only 2,000 acres are available for expansion as against 5,000 acres in Delhi—means a third runway cannot be built. A planned second airport in Navi Mumbai is embroiled in environment clearance hassles. "If the first phase of this airport is not up and running by 2014, we are in for dire times," predicts a Mumbai airport official.

The absence of anticipation and scale is best illustrated at the Bangalore airport. With nearly 11 million passengers, the Bangalore International Airport Ltd has already crossed the planned capacity for 2010. But the planners are blind to this growth. At 35 per cent, the city is projected to add over 3.85 million passengers a year. At this rate, traffic volume could cross 15 million by 2010. Yet the planned capacity for 2015 is pegged at 15 million passengers. "The model of a giant stand-alone airport is fatally flawed," says FICCI President Rajeev Chandrasekhar. "What we need are additional satellite airports like those in London and New York to decongest airports," he adds. This makes sense because unlike Singapore, Hong Kong and Kuala Lumpur which are global hubs, Indian airports operate as point-to-point services to service larger volumes of domestic traffic.

The Government's old policy of not allowing a second airport to come up in a 150-km vicinity is already under siege. The policy was also written into contracts of all the private developers to ensure profitability. A proposal for Delhi's second airport in Jevar, Noida, is still deadlocked between the Civil Aviation Ministry and the GMR-led consortium DIAL which believes subsidies to the airport from the Uttar Pradesh Government could divert traffic there. In Bangalore, authorities are already reconsidering an earlier plan to shut the HAL airport soon after the inauguration of the new airport at Devanahalli on May 11.

"You cannot lose existing infrastructure just because the new one is a greenfield airport," says Captain G.R. Gopinath, the father of low-cost air travel in India. Carving out an au-